

“India is a continent and should be divided into separate nations. There is no need for a single government.”

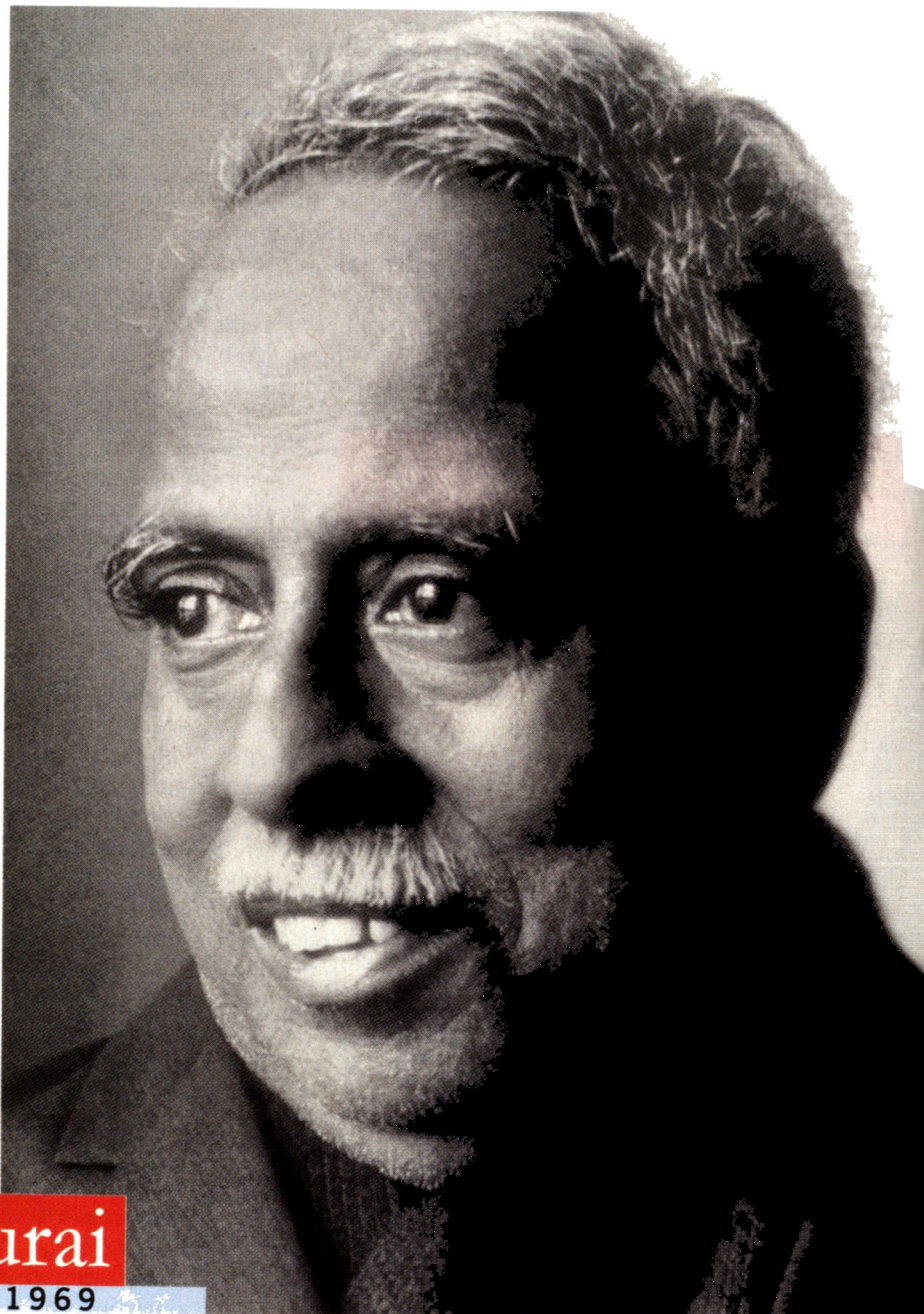
LETTER AND SPIRIT

A powerful orator and magnetic writer, the first leader of post-Independence India who did not play a role in the freedom struggle, gave voice to the aspirations of upwardly mobile non-Brahmin youth and safely accommodated Tamil nationalism within the state

■ **By A.R. Venkatachalapathy**

When Conjeevaram Natarajan Annadurai died, his funeral, attended by many lakhs of people, was one of the largest the country had seen—and as Indians are often fond of claiming—it is supposed to be a Guinness record. Anna, not only the diminutive of his name but which means “respected elder brother” as well in Tamil (an ambiguity capitalised on by the Dravidian movement), was born of rather undistinguished parentage for which he was often ridiculed by petty-minded political rivals. In the rise of this barely five-and-a-quarter feet man with a balding pate, tobacco-stained teeth, stubbled chin and a captivating husky voice to prominence lies the story of modern Tamil Nadu.

Anna was the first leader of post Independence India who did not play a role in the freedom struggle. Education—an M.A. proudly tagged to his name—was his only claim to respect and he cut his political teeth in the non-Brahmin Justice Party, translating into Tamil the high-flown public speeches of its leaders. The first anti-Hindi agitation of 1937–39 clearly established his skills with language—on the platform and with the pen to which he later added film script writing. In him Periyar E.V. Ramasamy found the lieutenant



C.N. Annadurai

Politician 1909–1969